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The Harvest Festival

Sterling Castle, Norfolk, Autumn 1851

Scene 4 · Festival dinner in the great hall

The great hall had been dressed for the harvest since Thursday. Sheaves stood bound in the corners, and swags of wheat and red ribbon ran the length of the gallery rail, and someone, in a spirit Alexander suspected was Catherine's, had set Farmer Hodge's prize marrow in the middle of the high table between two branches of candles, where it lay in state like a bishop. The fire was built high. The long table was full: the Reverend Mr. Ashby and his wife, the Fenwicks and the Hodges and the other senior tenants in their best, the Lowndes from Holt, Thomas Barrow in his formal coat looking as if it pinched him. Wood smoke and beeswax and roast goose. And under the door at the bottom of the hall, where it always came in on a September night, a thin draught that found Alexander's ankles and stayed there.

He had dressed. He had stood in front of his fire for ten minutes before he went down, and he was still cold.

The Count had been put at his mother's right hand, as a foreign nobleman must be, and Catherine directly across from him, as no one had intended. Miss Gray sat two places down from the Count. She had walked the two miles from her cottage before the lamps were lit, as she always did, and had spent the hour before dinner upstairs with his mother, as she always did, and she had come down to table in the same grey wool she wore to walk in, with the same plain amulet at her throat. She was tall and spare and very straight, with dark hair and a single streak of white in it, and a face the weather had worked on for a great many years. Alexander had known her all his life as his mother's odd friend, who smelled of lavender and woodsmoke and old paper, and who had once, when he was six, looked into a basin of water for him and told him gravely that he would be tall.

O'Brien moved behind the chairs with the wine. The steward was sixty, silver-haired, and pressed as sharp as a new card, and he had spent forty years at this table being noticed by no one, which was his art. His face gave away nothing at all. It never did.

Alexander had wanted one thing from the evening, which was for it to pass. He wanted the goose carved and the toasts made and the Reverend Mr. Ashby's speech about the harvest got through in under a quarter of an hour, and he wanted his sister not to begin on the Rhine. Catherine at a dinner table with a stranger who had travelled was a horse with the bit between its teeth.

She began on the Rhine before the soup was cleared.

It was not, in fairness, her fault. The Count drew her out. He did it very well, with small questions laid down one at a time like a man setting out cards, and he listened to her answers in a way Alexander had never seen anyone listen to Catherine. He did not listen the way their father did, with patience, or the way Alexander did, with half his mind elsewhere. He listened the way a locksmith listens to the tumblers of a lock, with his head a little on one side, as though each word she said was falling into place somewhere inside her and he could hear it land.

"My mother has friends abroad," Catherine was saying, "who write to her. One in Vienna and one in Pest and an old gentleman in Ragusa who writes entirely about his figs. They send the most wonderful letters. About the opera, and the ice on the river, and a procession with lanterns that went all the way down to the water." Her colour was high. She had drunk half a glass of claret and eaten nothing, and she leaned across the cloth toward him with her hands folded under her chin. "Have you been on the Danube, Count?"

"I was born above it," Hessian said.

He told her about it. He told it well. He described a gorge in the far east of the Empire where the river went through the mountains between cliffs so high and so close that the sun reached the water for an hour a day; the Iron Gates, he said, the boatmen called it, and they crossed themselves going in. He described whirlpools that could turn a barge end for end, and a fortress on a crag above them where the wind never stopped, and the villages of the Carpathians where the women painted their doors blue against the evil eye. He had a low, unhurried voice that made the hall seem to lean in toward it, and the Hodges at the far end had stopped eating to listen. It was a fine account. Alexander noticed, without quite meaning to, that the Count had

eaten nothing while he gave it. His goose lay carved on his plate and he had moved it from one side to the other with his fork, once, as a man might move a piece on a board. His wine stood untouched at his right hand. As he finished speaking he put out two fingers and turned the glass a quarter turn on the cloth, and left it.

Catherine had not taken her eyes from him.

"Can you imagine?" she said. She said it not to him but to the table, to all of them, as if it had been forced out of her. "Actually seeing any of it. Not reading it in someone's letters home. Seeing it?"

Hessian did not answer. He looked at her, and his face did the thing it had done on the steps: it went still, and in the stillness it stopped being any particular age. But it was not the same stillness. On the steps it had been the stillness of a man startled. This was the stillness of a man who has been listening for a long time at a door and has at last heard, from the other side, the sound he was waiting for.

Then he smiled at her, the good smile, and the moment passed, and the Reverend Mr. Ashby began to say something about the Euphrates in the Book of Revelation.

"He powders," Catherine said, low, to Alexander, under cover of it. She had leaned toward him behind her glass. "Did you see? At his collar. There's a line where it stops." She looked delighted. "I think it's rather sweet. A great foreign count, and he's vain as a curate."

Alexander looked. In the candlelight there was, perhaps, a faint pale line along the edge of the Count's collar where the skin above it was a shade whiter than the skin below. He would not have seen it if she had not told him. He decided she was right, and that it was sweet, and that he did not like it.

"Don't stare," he said. "You'll embarrass him."

"I never embarrass anyone. I'm a delight." But she sat back.

It was then that Alexander noticed Miss Gray.

She had not spoken through the whole of the Count's account. She sat very upright with her hands in her lap, and now one of them had come up to the amulet at her throat and closed on it. Her left eye, the odd one, which had always caught the light strangely, had clouded over like a

pane of glass when someone breathes on it, and as he watched, a thin silver came up into the cloud from underneath, the way a tarnished spoon shows its silver when it is rubbed. She was looking at the Count. Then she looked down the table at Alexander's mother, a long look, and she opened her mouth.

She closed it again. Her hand stayed on the amulet. She said nothing at all.

Alexander had seen her eye do that before, at christenings and funerals, once when a storm came in off the sea. It was Miss Gray's oddness. Everyone in the district knew about it and no one remarked on it, as no one remarked on the vicar's limp. He looked away from her and back to his plate, and when he looked up again the silver had gone out of the eye and it was only grey.

"You said this evening that you'd come about land, Count." His father's voice came down the table, easy and pleasant, the voice he used at tenants' dinners to bring a conversation round from wherever it had wandered to wherever he wanted it. He had thirty years of practice at it and it showed. "You'll find Norfolk poor hunting for that. We drain what we have and keep it. But if it's remote ground that interests you, there's land in the north of Scotland that nobody has wanted in a hundred years."

Hessian turned his head. "In the north?"

"Wester Ross. Near Loch Maree. Rock and heather and a good deal of weather." His father reached for his own glass. "My grandfather used to say it was the only property he owned that had never once given him trouble, because there was nothing on it to give any."

"How very restful," Hessian said. "I collect land that no one else particularly wants. It is a foreign eccentricity."

Alexander looked at his father. He could not think why he had brought it up. The northern tract was a line in the ledgers even more remote than Harrow's Fen, a figure for rates and nothing else, and he had never in his life heard his father offer anything to anyone across a dinner table. His mother's face was perfectly calm. She was cutting a piece of goose very small.

The talk went on. The toasts were made. The Reverend Mr. Ashby's speech ran to twenty minutes. Before the ladies rose, the Count excused himself, with his grave correct courtesy, to

take a little air, and O'Brien drew back his chair, and he went out by the door at the bottom of the hall where the draught came in.

O'Brien came along the table behind him to clear his place. He lifted the Count's plate with the goose still on it, and then the Count's glass, and Alexander, watching for no reason he could name, saw that the wine in it stood exactly as high as it had when O'Brien poured it. Not a sip. Not the smallest mark on the rim.

O'Brien's face gave away nothing. He carried the full glass out with the plate as though it were empty, and Alexander, who did not like the Count, told himself that a foreigner might very well not care for claret.

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Added Details not in Scene Packet

Every detail in this scene that its scene packet does not supply, in the order it appears. Items marked *decided* have since been approved and recorded in the planning documents. Everything else is open to change in the next draft.

The hall

- Sheaves in the corners, wheat and red ribbon on the gallery rail, Hodge's marrow on the high table "like a bishop."
- Guests: the Reverend Mr. and Mrs. Ashby, the Fenwicks, the Hodges, the Lowndes from Holt, Thomas Barrow.
- Hessian sits at Amelia's right, and Catherine across from him.
- Seraphina walked over before the lamps were lit and spent the hour before dinner upstairs with Amelia.
- When Alexander was six, Seraphina looked into a basin of water and told him he would be tall.
- O'Brien is "pressed as sharp as a new card."

The talk

- Amelia's correspondents are in Vienna, in Pest, and in Ragusa (an old gentleman who writes only about his figs). Catherine mentions a lantern procession to the water.
- Hessian: "I was born above it." He describes the Iron Gates, whirlpools, a fortress on a crag, and blue doors against the evil eye.
- He moves his goose once with his fork, eats nothing, and turns his glass a quarter turn.
- Catherine: "He powders... vain as a curate." "I never embarrass anyone. I'm a delight."
- Seraphina's eye clouds "like a pane of glass when someone breathes on it." Alexander has seen it before, at christenings, funerals, and once in a storm.
- The vicar has a limp.
- Mr. Ashby's speech mentions the Euphrates in Revelation and runs twenty minutes.

Edward's land

- Edward: "Wester Ross. Near Loch Maree. Rock and heather and a good deal of weather."
- Edward's grandfather said it was the only property that never gave him trouble.
- Hessian: "It is a foreign eccentricity."
- Hessian leaves by the door where the draught comes in. His wine is untouched, with no mark on the rim.